services, and agents. Access is no longer something that can be granted once and left unchanged. It must be evaluated every time it matters.

This shift may seem large, but you don't need to start with a complete transformation. You can make meaningful progress through small, intentional changes. Make your authorization decisions visible. Externalize a policy domain. Introduce consistent evaluation. Strengthen governance of signals and delegation. Design your systems so decisions can be made at runtime.

You can start by tackling one access problem that’s causing friction or is the source of security problems. Identify a rule or permission that is hard to explain, change, or enforce consistently. Make it visible. Integrate it into a shared policy. Evaluate it using real-world context that reflects how your system actually operates. Learn from the outcomes. Then, apply the same approach to the next decision.

Over time, these changes accumulate. Decisions become simpler to make. Behavior becomes more consistent. Introducing new capabilities becomes easier without raising risk. What starts as a local improvement eventually becomes part of how your systems function.

As we’ve seen, the future of access control is not defined by roles or rules alone. Rather, it’s defined by the ability to make decisions continuously, based on policy and context, as conditions change. *You do not have to build that future all at once. But you can begin building it now.*

19.10 Summary

- Authorization typically starts as a local implementation issue but grows into a system-wide limitation as complexity increases.
- Incremental improvements to access control accumulate over time, influencing how systems develop and how organizations function.
- Inconsistent authorization logic causes fragmented user experiences, operational friction, and missed opportunities.
- As systems grow, the decision surface—the set of situations in which access must be evaluated—expands rapidly across people, services, and